Many of the young supporters who flocked to Amona opposed the community's deal with the state. "We have to convince the youth to accept it," a resident said. On 15 December, days before the evacuation deadline, police arrested a 22-year-old man for threatening to kill Bennett. He allegedly sent a message to a Whatsapp group that included a photo of the Israeli flag next to an Uzi. "Someone ought to take out Naftali Bennett," he wrote. The Shin Bet had already increased Bennett's security detail, too.

Yet Shmuel Rosner, a peripatetic Israeli journalist, wrote an op-ed for the *New York Times* arguing that all of this was actually a positive sign. "The government—even if reluctantly—abides by the law and will follow the court's ruling," he wrote. "It's now a cliché that the settler movement has an undue influence over the Israeli government. But the Amona evacuation is evidence, once again, that this common knowledge is wrong."[1]

To borrow a phrase from George W. Bush, this was the soft bigotry of low expectations: arguing that a few hundred settlers didn't have "undue influence" because the government was unwilling to totally subvert the rule of law to support them. Ignore how the prime minister spent literally weeks trying to placate forty families who violated Israeli law, and how the Knesset spent hours debating their fate instead of, say, the 21 per cent of Israelis who live in poverty, or the hundreds of thousands of students lagging behind their Western peers in math and science. Disregard the fact that lawmakers ultimately voted to authorize thousands of other illegal homes across the West Bank, creating a supreme moral hazard. The caravans in Amona would be bulldozed. Israeli democracy was healthy.

The backstabber

The rest of the world wasn't convinced. On 21 December, Egypt circulated a resolution at the Security Council that declared Israeli settlements to "have no legal validity". Such measures pop up every few years; they are usually swatted down by the United States, which wields a veto. But there was a sense in Jerusalem that President Obama, after eight years of clashes with Netanyahu, had finally reached the end of his tether, and would allow it to pass.

Hours before the vote, though, Egypt unexpectedly pulled the measure. The reason, according to diplomats, was Donald Trump. The Israeli ambassador in Washington, Ron Dermer, called him on the afternoon of 22